sort of support base within the country can be a significant obstacle to progress. Decades of isolationism and authoritarianism make change a real challenge to the new regime. Finally, the inherent fragile nature of Myanmar with major rifts along ethnic and religious lines may slow reform initiatives. Efforts to resolve longstanding grievances with several ethnic groups must be a high priority.

THE FUTURE OF MYANMAR

Thein Sein has moved rapidly to begin implementing significant reforms first set out in his March 2011 inaugural address. Opponents of the regime are beginning a dialogue with the administration, as potential breakthroughs are a distinct possibility. Members of the NLD, including Aung San Suu Kyi, have met in Naypyidaw with the leaders of the junta, including Thein Sein. Furthermore, ASEAN, the main regional organization, continues to push for positive change and powers India and China seem to be working to encourage Myanmar to move in a positive direction toward open engagement with the international community.

Thein Sein's inaugural address and the August 2011 speech seem to be opening a new chapter in the history of Myanmar. Critics claim this to be empty rhetoric, but the regime has taken real concrete steps in the direction of openness in both the political and economic realm. The three key areas that are included in the reform agenda include reinvigorating the economy, reforming national politics, and dealing effectively with human rights issues.

The governmental changes that occurred in late March 2011 seemed superficial on the surface. Most members of the new government were at one time tied to the military. President Thein Sein was the prime minister during the previous administration. On a deeper substantive level, the changes seem to be more concrete. Reconciliation with opposition parties and with the ethnic minority groups has taken a high priority.

Following the seminal inaugural address by Thein Sein, plans were underway to begin steps toward change. A key early step was the government assistance in helping to facilitate Aung San Suu Kyi's attendance at Martyrs' Day, the annual celebration honoring her father's role in the independence movement in Myanmar. This was the first time in